CHAPTER 16

SCALING HEAVEN

Who, my friend, can scale heaven?

—THE EPIC OF GILGAMESH

(SUMER, THIRD MILLENNIUM B.C.)

What?, I sometimes ask myself in amazement: Our ancestors walked from East Africa to Novaya Zemlya and Ayers Rock and Patagonia, hunted elephants with stone spearpoints, traversed the polar seas in open boats 7,000 years ago, circumnavigated the Earth propelled by nothing but wind, walked the Moon a decade after entering space—and we're daunted by a voyage to Mars? But then I remind myself of the avoidable human suffering on Earth, how a few dollars can save the life of a child dying of dehydration, how many children we could save for the cost of a trip to Mars—and for the moment I change my mind. Is it unworthy to stay home, or unworthy to go? Or have I posed a false dichotomy? Isn't it possible to make a better life for everyone on Earth *and* to reach for the planets and the stars?

We had an expansive run in the '60s and '70s. You might have thought, as I did then, that our species would be on Mars before the century was over. But instead, we've pulled inward. Robots aside, we've backed off from the planets and the stars. I keep asking myself: Is it a failure of nerve or a sign of maturity?

Maybe it's the most we could reasonably have expected. In a way it's amazing that it was possible at all: We sent a dozen humans on